Annual Records Digitisation Review

Northfield Regional Archive — Reporting Period 2024–25

1. Executive Summary

During the reporting period the archive converted 412,000 pages of paper records into searchable digital form, an increase of 18 per cent on the previous year. The majority of this material was typed correspondence in good condition, which the standard pipeline handled with a character accuracy above 99 per cent.

A smaller but significant portion of the intake consisted of handwritten notes, skewed photocopies and multi-page tables. These documents account for roughly one page in nine, yet they were responsible for more than half of all manual corrections logged by the review team. Improving the treatment of these difficult pages is therefore the main recommendation of this review.

2. Scope

The review covers all material received between 1 July 2024 and 30 June 2025 across the four regional offices. It does not include audio-visual holdings, maps larger than A2, or items restricted under the Privacy Schedule. Figures quoted in this document are drawn from the intake register and from a random sample of 2,000 pages checked by hand.

3. Method

Each sampled page was compared against a transcription prepared independently by two reviewers. Disagreements between reviewers were resolved by a third. Accuracy is reported at the character level for running text and at the cell level for tables, so that a single misplaced column does not hide behind otherwise correct text.

4. Findings

4.1 Page quality

Pages were grouped into three classes according to how they entered the archive:

- **Born-digital** pages exported directly from office software, with an embedded text layer and no visual noise.
- **Flatbed scans** of printed originals, generally straight but with occasional shadowing near the spine.
- **Sheet-fed or handheld captures**, often rotated by several degrees and frequently carrying handwritten annotations.

4.2 Common failure modes

1. Skew greater than five degrees causes lines to be merged or split.
2. Handwritten margin notes are interleaved with the printed paragraph beside them.
3. Tables without ruling lines lose their column boundaries.
4. Merged header cells are repeated or dropped in the output.

4.3 Discussion

None of these problems is new, and none is surprising. What the sample makes clear is how unevenly they are distributed. A straight, printed page almost never needs attention. A tilted page with ink annotations nearly always does. Routing pages by difficulty before processing, rather than applying one method to everything, would direct effort to where it is actually needed.

The pages that follow reproduce examples of each class, together with the summary tables used to prepare this review.

INTERNAL MEMORANDUM

To: Regional Operations Managers
From: Margaret Ellison, Head of Compliance
Date: 14 March 2025
Re: Revised document retention schedule

Following the internal audit completed in February, the retention schedule for customer correspondence has been revised. Effective 1 April 2025, all inbound paper correspondence must be scanned within two business days of receipt and the originals retained for a period of ninety days before secure destruction.

check with legal first!

Branches that currently hold more than six months of unscanned material are asked to submit a backlog estimate to the Compliance Office no later than 28 March 2025. Estimates should state the approximate number of pages, the share that is handwritten, and whether any items are bound or oversized.

backlog approx 4,200 pages

Please ensure that every team member has read and acknowledged this notice. Questions may be directed to compliance@northfield-example.org.

Received & noted - will send estimate by Friday 21/3.

J. Okafor

Branch Manager, Eastfield

Tuesday 18 March

Dear Tom,

Thanks for dropping off the boxes on Monday. I went through the first three last night and here is what I found:

- Box 1: invoices from 2019 to 2021, about 350 pages
- Box 2: mostly delivery dockets, some are water damaged
- Box 3: staff timesheets, all filled in by hand

The dockets will be the hardest to read. A few have coffee stains and the carbon copies are very faint.

Can you ask Priya whether we need to keep the duplicates? If not I will shred them on Thursday.

I still need the key for the filing cabinet in room 12. Call me on 0412 555 018 if it is easier.

Cheers,

Helen

5. Summary Tables

5.1 Intake and output by office

Office	Pages received	Pages digitised	Backlog	Completion
Northfield	148,200	141,950	6,250	95.8%
Eastfield	97,400	88,100	9,300	90.5%
Harrow Creek	112,750	109,300	3,450	96.9%
Port Albany	81,600	72,650	8,950	89.0%
Total	**439,950**	**412,000**	**27,950**	**93.6%**

Table 1. Pages received and digitised, 1 July 2024 to 30 June 2025.

5.2 Staffing

Role	FTE	Avg. pages / day
Scanner operator	6.0	1,150
Quality reviewer	3.5	420
Archivist	2.0	n/a

Table 2. Staffing levels at 30 June 2025.

Completion is calculated as pages digitised divided by pages received. Backlog carried over from earlier years is excluded from both figures.

5.3 Accuracy by page class

Page class	Share of intake	Character accuracy		Table cell accuracy		Manual fixes per 100 pages
		Mean	Worst 5%	Mean	Worst 5%	
Born-digital	46%	99.9%	99.6%	99.2%	96.0%	0.4
Flatbed scan	43%	99.1%	96.8%	95.5%	84.1%	3.1
Sheet-fed / handheld	11%	93.4%	71.2%	81.7%	48.9%	27.6
of which handwritten	*4%*	*86.0%*	*55.3%*	*n/a*	*n/a*	*41.2*

Table 3. Accuracy measured on a 2,000-page hand-checked sample. Header cells span two rows and two columns.

Table 3 shows the gap between the classes. The mean figures look acceptable for every class; the worst five per cent do not. For handheld captures the weakest pages lose more than half of their table cells.

5.4 Borderless table

Quarter	Received	Digitised	Rejected
Jul-Sep 2024	104,300	99,800	1,210
Oct-Dec 2024	98,750	95,100	980
Jan-Mar 2025	121,400	110,250	1,640
Apr-Jun 2025	115,500	106,850	1,395

Table 4. Quarterly volumes (no ruling lines).

6. Recommendations

The review team makes the following recommendations, in order of priority.

1. **Classify before processing.** Decide for each page whether it is born-digital, a clean scan or a difficult capture, and choose the method accordingly.
2. **Correct skew early.** Deskewing a page before recognition is cheap and removes the largest single cause of merged lines.
3. **Keep handwriting separate.** Annotations should be reported as their own blocks, with their position, rather than merged into the printed text.
4. **Measure tables at the cell level.** Text accuracy alone hides structural errors such as shifted columns.
5. **Re-sample quarterly.** A 500-page sample each quarter is enough to detect a change of two percentage points in accuracy.

7. Next Steps

A pilot of the classification step will run at the Eastfield office from August 2025. Eastfield was chosen because it holds the largest backlog and the highest share of handwritten material. Results will be reported to the Archive Board in November 2025.

The remaining pages of this document are appendices: a completed loan form, the full monthly figures, and a stocktake sheet with handwritten entries.

EQUIPMENT LOAN REQUEST FORM

Form EL-7 | Please complete in block letters

Full name: DANIEL R. WHITCOMBE

Department: Field Surveying

Employee no.: 48817

Item requested: Total station + tripod

Serial number: TS-2291-K

Loan period: 24 Mar to 11 Apr 2025

Site / location: Harrow Creek bridge works

Condition on issue (tick one):

☐ New ☑ Good ☐ Fair ☐ Damaged

Comments:

Left tripod leg clamp is a bit loose - tightened it but should be looked at when returned. Battery charger NOT included, borrowing one from stores.

Signature: D Whitcombe **Date:** 20/3/25

Appendix B. Monthly Pages Digitised

Month	Northfield	Eastfield	Harrow Creek	Port Albany	Total	Cost (AUD)
Jul 2024	12,352	8,107	9,025	6,240	35,724	4,894.19
Aug 2024	12,905	6,977	8,478	6,846	35,206	4,823.22
Sep 2024	12,596	8,148	9,389	6,457	36,590	5,012.83
Oct 2024	11,262	6,585	9,014	5,821	32,682	4,477.43
Nov 2024	11,080	6,571	9,203	6,858	33,712	4,618.54
Dec 2024	13,098	6,371	9,319	6,011	34,799	4,767.46
Jan 2025	12,355	6,845	9,376	5,230	33,806	4,631.42
Feb 2025	12,664	6,458	8,221	5,273	32,616	4,468.39
Mar 2025	11,279	7,190	9,328	5,261	33,058	4,528.95
Apr 2025	12,400	7,536	9,002	6,410	35,348	4,842.68
May 2025	11,300	8,326	8,578	6,511	34,715	4,755.95
Jun 2025	11,704	8,247	8,109	6,556	34,616	4,742.39
Total	**144,995**	**87,361**	**107,042**	**73,474**	**412,872**	**56,563.46**

Table 5. Pages digitised per office per month; cost at AUD 0.137 per page.

Stocktake Sheet - Warehouse B, Aisle 4

Counted by: R. Singh Date: 19/3/25

Bin	Description	System	Counted	Diff
B4-01	Hex bolt M10 x 40	1,200	1,185	-15
B4-02	Hex nut M10	2,400	2,400	0
B4-03	Flat washer 10 mm	3,000	2,950	-50
B4-04	Spring washer 10 mm	1,500	1,512	+12
B4-05	Coach screw 8 x 75	800	~~764~~ 746	-36
B4-06	Anchor sleeve 12 mm	450	450	0
B4-07	Threaded rod M12 1 m	120	118	-2
B4-08	Cable tie 300 mm (pk)	95	101	+6

Notes: B4-03 short again - 2nd month running. B4-05 recount done twice, use the red figure. Report to M. Avery.